

ON BECOMING A STOCKBROKER

THE GILLETTE BEING FIVE POINTS AHEAD PLUS THE EARLIER GAIN on the option still didn't make up for the shrinking Angstrom, and by the end of April the \$10,920.31 I'd invested was worth only \$9,019.88, a loss of \$910.42. At this point, I began to think I should become a stockbroker.

When I considered the negative income, and added up the hours it took to achieve it, almost any paying job began to sound good. First, I realized I'd have been better off picking tomatoes or scrap- ing boats. Even if I'd volunteered my time to the United Way at least I wouldn't have been out the \$910.42. I remembered that Ms. Garrett had been making a pleasant living during this entire struggle. Whatever her personal losses from Angstrom, they were cushioned by several commissions from me. In fact, being a stock- broker was one of the few proven risk-free methods of investing I'd encountered so far.

I found out it took four months from the day an aspiring stock- broker put in the application to the day he or she advised the first client. This compared favorably with six months for licensed beauty- parlor operators, and two years for plumbers certified to unclog drains. I could have become a broker twice in the time I'd spent on this project to date. Surely I'd spent more hours bungling my investments than it would take to graduate from broker's school.

The aspiring stockbroker is hired by a local branch office like those I visited earlier. There's three months of on-site training: processing orders, answering telephones, learning the paperwork, and studying for the Series 7 exam. The Series 7 exam is given by the SEC and covers basic rules and regulations of Wall Street. Sixty percent pass it, so it couldn't be too hard. The survivors are